



LAVANYA LAKSHMI NARAYANAN

lost form in a matter of an hour, with the Diary resorting to the visual massacre of scooping up pieces with a spoon.

The 90-plus-year-old venue, a relic of British India with its timeless Art Deco design and colonial club culture, had its quirks.

While the press box was at the Churchgate End, the post-match media interactions would be held in the pavilion building. Reporters who needed to catch trains smartly tried to make their way back to the other end, given its proximity to Churchgate station, only to find that the gates had been locked. The Diary whipped out ambulance and police siren sounds in an attempt to attract the attention of the security personnel — who, we later discovered, were standing right outside — but in vain.

The final week of the WPL had high-profile names slotted in for the mid-innings shows, including global stars like Hanumankind and French Montana. The Diary — who swears by Punjabi music in good times and bad — also got a glimpse of the powerhouse that is Jasmine Sandlas. That these stars only performed for the Pavilion End took

away some of the cheer for the mortals in the rest of the seats.

One of the most joyous parts of working at Brabourne (**above, left**) was the countless encounters with the friendly in-house cats. The Diary — away from her own dog and cat — had similar comforts at the office of *The Hindu*, where she was staying. The in-house patriarch, Lucky — a chonky indie fattened by the food and adoration provided by those working in the building — and his band of over a dozen cats helped the Diary unwind after a long day with some playtime.

The day of the final brought out Mumbai's maddest best (**below**). The roadways around the CCI were packed. **Fans, mostly Mumbai Indians faithfuls, filled 14,700 of the 17,000-odd seats in the house. One could spot the odd CSK and RCB shirt too.** MI set the template once more, with incredible installations at Churchgate railway station. There were hoardings of the players with their names written to help fans identify them. Alongside were statues of cricketers and women from all walks of life in MI jerseys. It was a raging hit, with countless people stopping for videos and

photographs. As unbiased as the press pack tries to be, the Diary can confidently say that most had a prayer on their lips for Delhi Capitals skipper Meg Lanning. One of the best captains in the history of the sport, her luck with WPL finals was a cruel corrective activity by the forces of the universe. The evening would follow that same fateful script.

While fans grimaced when Delhi lost its openers — fearing the game was done right there — the team's batting order resisted, dragging the game to the very end but ultimately falling short by eight runs. While the home crowd undid the purpose of the 10 pm loudspeaker curfew with their thundering cheers, they also stood up in applause for a DC side that refused to give up.

The press contingent spent its dying minutes on WPL duty pondering the ifs and what-ifs. Will Lanning return next year? Will talismanic MI coach Charlotte Edwards (**above, right**) finally consider the top job with a struggling England national side? Will we see new teams next year?

One will have to make peace with the uncertainties and possibilities of this ellipsis, at least for now.

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